



Michigan is a folksy pop rock musical that follows Petoskey Vandam and Lulu Abughosh, a grieving Yoooper boy and Dearborn girl, fight a data center to save their grandparents' historic lake house.

Michigan

Inspired by
The MacGregor Family
David Quang Pham's Childhood

&

In Loving Memory of
Andrew "Andy" Van Otteren
March 17, 1994 - July 12, 2026
Tiffany Marie Emmert
April 29, 1996 - January 19, 2026
James Emmert
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Thanks to you all, David and countless others
love musical theatre and Michigan.

Michigan

SYNOPSIS

To save their grandparents' lake house from becoming a data center, a Dearborn girl and her grieving Yooper cousin must bridge their peninsula-sized rivalry, proving blood is thicker than the Mackinac Strait. To buy back the home, they must trade Petoskey's late father's treasured heirloom (a heart-shaped Petoskey necklace with an elk symbol) which Lulu lost in Elk Lake years ago. Petoskey, a native fossil that reveals its true pattern when wet, serves as a metaphor for hidden grief and emotional depth.

Michigan is inspired by David Quang Pham's upbringing and the MacGregors who invite him to their Elk Rapids lake house on Harbor Days since being roommates with their family member Lukas Jacob in 2014. In 2026, after a series of suicides of his hometown and college friends in musical theatre, he began writing this musical as a love letter to his family and communities in our home Mitten.

WHY NOW?

Michigan champions human connection, creativity, and nature against the rising tide of technological isolation, symbolized by the threat of replacing a historic lake house with an AI data center. By centering its narrative on the long-term impact of suicide and collective loss, the play directly addresses our modern mental health crisis, offering a vital roadmap for healing through open communication and community. Furthermore, it uses localized science and folklore to bridge regional cultural divides, reminding audiences to protect both the natural environments and the shared, real-world heritages that keep us rooted.

Michigan is the homeliness of *Oklahoma* meets the whimsiness of *Waitress* meets the folksiness of *Bright Star*.

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THEMES

Collective Grief and Emotional Healing

The story explores the long-term impact of grief after Petey's suicide and Grandma Milly's death, demonstrating how silence fractures families while open communication fosters generational healing.

Community versus Technology

The central conflict pits a warm hand-made tradition against cold corporate greed, by keeping AI data centers from erasing local heritage, such as the family's lake house.

Geographic and Cultural Disconnection

The narrative highlights how families can become polarized by peninsulas, symbolized by the physical and emotional barrier of the Mackinac Bridge separating the Upper and Lower Peninsula identities. The story leans into subcultures, contrasting Yooper (Upper Peninsula) against suburban Dearborn/Lower Peninsula dynamics.

Belonging and Identity

Through Lulu's competitive drive to outshine her cousins, the musical examines the painful adolescent struggle to fit into a Midwest family dynamic and find one's own sense of worth.

Nature, Folklore, and Science Literacy

By embedding paleontology into the musical numbers, the narrative uses the natural history of the Petoskey stone fossil to teach environmental appreciation and show how memories attach themselves to physical landscapes.

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The Immigrant Experience

This manifests through multiple layers, such as Shelby marrying an Arab man, Jasper Tran's Vietnamese restaurant (Banh MiMichigan), and Jasper's realization that his refugee family stayed united across continents while local families are divided by peninsulas. It deals heavily with how different minority communities interact within the Midwest.

Economic Displacement and Xenophobia

The backstory reveals the harsh realities of blue-collar job loss during the 2008 recession, like David's family in the automotive industry. It directly addresses the displaced anger that can arise from automated or immigrant replacement (Petey being fired and replaced by a migrant worker), showing the tragic intersection of economic desperation, racial tension, and family fallout.

The Power of Hand-Made Artistry

The family's century-old Ford Model T, their decades of hand-made costumes, and the town's rally around them showcase art and weirdness as a form of liberation.

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PLOT SUMMARY

Michigan is a folksy musical dramedy set at a family reunion where two rival cousins fight a data center to save their grandparents' historic lake house. The themes explore grief, cultural disconnection of the peninsulas, and what it means to be a Michigander.

Grampy Willy and Granny Milly live in Elk Rapids on the north tip of the Lower Peninsula. They have four adult children – Cherry, Perry, Shelby, and the only son Petey, and some grandchildren. Every August, their lake house lodges them for the annual Harbor Days. The Vandam family are known for their century-old Ford Model T, wearing themed costumes for the parade, and winning every Most Creative Award (“[The Mitten Song](#)”).

In 2008, Petey lives with his pregnant wife Lizzie in the Upper Peninsula. His childhood friend is Jasper Tran, who runs the Banh Mlchigan, a Vietnamese restaurant in Elk Rapids. On a swim, Petey jokily promises to name their kid after the first rock he picks up: a heart-shaped Petoskey with an elk symbol (“[Life is Complete](#)”).

But in the recession, their shipyard job fires Petey and Liz, with Arab migrants replacing them. He gets in a fight with his little sister Shelby due to her Arab husband. In a storm, he drives off the Mackinac Bridge to save their house on his life insurance. The detective finds Petey's Petoskey. Following his death, Liz refuses to cross the bridge, missing many family gatherings. And Harbor Day mornings feel hollow without goofy Petey to wake them up with songs until his son Petoskey was of age to sing them (“[Body of Water](#)”).

For family reunions, the aunts take turns driving him to Elk Rapids then Milly drives him home, while Jasper becomes his godfather. For every Mackinac Bridge crossing, he can hear his dad sing. And then there's his bright cousin from Dearborn, Lulu Abughoush. She always competes to find the rarest stones on their swims. In 2019, she tosses his heirloom into Elk Lake, severing his spiritual ties to his dad (“[Yoopers and Trolls](#)”).

In 2020, Milly passes away, cancelling the 2020 and 2021 family reunions. Soon, data center developer Amy Wayland tricks a grieving Willy into signing away the deed to his house by using afterlife.ai to bring Milly and Petey back to life (“[It Would Be a Shame](#)”).

In 2022, to honor Milly, 13-year-old Petoskey's mother returns for the first time since the 2008 tragedy. They drive the long way through Wisconsin. Jasper helps Petoskey, Lulu, and the other kids set up camp and go canoeing with them. He often takes some of their snacks as “dad tax.” The aunties take even more with “mom taxes” (“[Dad Tax](#)”).

With Willy believing Milly and Petey are still alive through AI, they discover Wayland's plot to turn the neighborhood into a data center. She and Cherry were art school rivals. Wayland tours the home and sees a photo of toddler Petoskey and his hearty stone. She wants it. Worth more than the whole neighborhood, the boy promises to trade it for the deed. They have a day to find the necklace at the bottom of Elk Lake (“[Affordable](#)”).

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Conveniently, Jasper and Aunt Perry run a scuba diving company. But they could not find the heirloom ("Heirlooms"). The next few nights, Lulu and Petoskey witness deer pass by the bonfire. He wishes to see his dad while she hopes to win this year's rock collection ("Dearborn"). One day, while Perry teaches fossils to the kids ("Fossils in the Stones"), Lulu separates from the group and discovers a deer drop off the hearty Petoskey necklace and other rare stones on the shore ("The Great Lakes Ballet").

For Harbor Days' parade, Broadway actor cousin Jacob Jacobowitz is the MC. So, the theme is theatre. Petoskey dresses as *Oklahoma's* Jud Fry while Lulu plays Evan Hansen. Before marching, she shows her rare stone findings to the family. To spite Petoskey, she breaks his father's necklace, unaware it was their only chance to save the lake house from Wayland. The parade goes wrong as Petoskey beats up Lulu, disqualifying them for the first time ("Fraudway"). After a lecture, he runs away ("Kick Rocks").

In the following act, the family revisits a memory of Lulu and Petoskey meeting ("Hands Come in Handy"). Presently, they search for him while Lulu tries to find him at Banh MI ("Petoskey"). Jasper shares his refugee family stayed united despite continents dividing them as well as a time when a Lebanese family bought out his family's failing restaurant but did not resort to blame as Petey had. The Vandams are only divided by peninsulas. Lulu realizes Petoskey is most likely at the Mackinac Bridge ("North South East West").

They drive up to find him. She offers the broken stone as a truce, but he tosses it into the water ("Rock Bottom"). This causes the bridge to fog up where his father's ghost emerges as a giant elk. Petey shares that stones are special only when rocks are packed together. Like family, rocks come and go to leave a mark ("Family's in the Fossils").

They return to the fair where Wayland is exhibiting data center models with other developers. Petoskey offers the Ford which she scoffs but is interested in. Jasper then offers his restaurant. The Vandams return with decades of themed costume while Wayland shows how much "better" AI is. But the town rallies for this genuinely creative and weird family, against AI's goal of turning lakes into data centers. Wayland and the developers refuse and steal the Ford, causing the town to chase after them. She drives it off a bridge, then gets thrown into an asylum by Traverse City. Their contracts are declared void as their party is declared insane ("Leave No Stones Unturned").

After Harbor Days conclude, Liz takes the Ford for a spin and go the short way to the Mackinac Bridge, the first time since Petey's death. Liz and Petey's ghost have their own reunion as lovers once more ("Spirits Under the Bridge").

Years later, Willy passes away. Lulu and Petoskey buy and fix up the lake house. For the 2037 Harbor Days which celebrates two hundred years of statehood, the theme is Pure Michigan where the Vandam family resembles the state's best ("Michigan").

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

THE VANDAM FAMILY

PETOSKEY VANDAM is a 13-year-old farm boy from Skandia and the goofiest of Willy and Milly's grandchildren. Besides his mom Liz, the only connection to his extended family happens on Harbor Days in Elk Rapids. He never met his deceased dad. To honor Petey, his son wears his heart-shaped Petoskey necklace with an elk symbol and awakens folks with his Mitten Song.

LIZZIE VANDAM is Petoskey's mother and narrator from Skandia. After her husband Petey's suicide in 2008, she stops crossing the Mackinac Bridge to attend Harbor Days and all family gatherings. Liz is a proud farm girl Yooper.

PETEY VANDAM is Petoskey's father, Liz's husband, and Willy and Milly's only son of four. Every Harbor Days, he would be the first to get up to wake everyone up with mittens. During the recession, his blue-collar shipyard job fires him and Liz and replaces them with Arab migrants, leading to a fight with his younger sister Shelby for marrying an Arab. He would drive off the Mackinac Bridge to save their house with his life insurance. His ghost visits Petoskey whenever he crosses the bridge, and he hopes Liz visit agains.

LULU ABUGHOUSH is a 13-year-old city girl from Dearborn and Willy and Milly's brightest grandkid, yet is trollface personified. Despite going above and beyond, she and her mom Shelby feel out of place. She hopes to beat cousin Petoskey in their annual water rock collection. She loves Iggy Pop and her favorite musical is Dear Evan Hansen. Her name means "pearl" in Arabic.

SHELBY ABUGHOUSH is Petoskey's aunt, Petey's little sister, and Lulu's mother who lives in Dearborn. She is an automotive worker for Ford Motor Company. As the sister who broke the mold by falling in love with an Arab, she and Petey had a tumultuous relationship. She tries to respect Petoskey.

PERRY VANDAM is Petoskey's aunt and Petey's older sister in Lansing. With science on her campy mind, she runs a scuba diving company with Jasper.

CHERRY JACOBOWITZ is Petoskey's aunt and Petey's oldest sister in Kalamazoo. She arranges the theme and costumes for the annual Harbor Days parade. She is married to a Grand Rapids Griffins hockey manager.

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JACOB JACOBOWITZ is Cherry's son who is a successful Broadway actor in New York City. He is the Master of Ceremony for the 2022 Harbor Days Parade where he is dressed as Wednesday from *The Addams Family*. He recently performed in the national tour of this show.

MILLY VANDAM is Petoskey's bold grandmother and inventor. She invented the automatic toilet. With Willy, she owns a house by Elk Lake in Elk Rapids. She and Willy stumble into the audience every so often.

WILLY VANDAM is Petoskey's chill grandfather and gardener. With Milly, he owns a lake house by Elk Lake in Elk Rapids. Grieving Milly's death in 2020, he leaves the garden unattended and accidentally signs away the deed. He and Milly stumble into the audience every so often.

ELK RAPIDS RESIDENTS

JASPER TRAN is Petey's resourceful childhood friend and Petoskey's godfather who runs the BANH Michigan Vietnamese restaurant, a scuba diving company with Aunt Perry, and a golf course for the heck of it. As a teen, he once looked down on the Arab community when a Lebanese family bought out his family's previous struggling restaurant. After Petey's passing with the last memory of him being his prejudice towards Arabs for "stealing American jobs," he vows to help migrants no matter what.

AMANDA WAYLAND is the sketchy CEO of Turkey Ventures and the creator of afterlife.ai whose mission is to turn the Elk Lake neighborhood into a data center. Before flunking out of art school for using Photoshop, she was a rival to her classmate, Cherry Vandam. So, she sees the Vandam family's hands-on creativity as inferior to the efficiency of AI. The Vandams describe her as a turkey vulture. But like most sane people in the world, there is one thing she likes more than data and that is a cool rock, which Petoskey holds.

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MUSICAL NUMBERS

ACT I

1. [Overture / The Mitten Song](#) Petey
2. [Life is Complete](#) The Vandams
3. [Body of Water](#) Petey, Lizzie
4. [Yoopers and Trolls](#) Petoskey, Lulu
5. [It Would Be a Shame](#) Wayland, Willy, Milly, Petey
6. [Dad Tax](#) Jasper, Lizzie, Cherry, Perry, Shelby, Lulu, Petoskey, Kids
7. Affordable Wayland, The Vandams
8. Heirlooms Jasper, Perry, Petoskey, Lulu
9. Dearborn (Dear Deer) Petoskey, Lulu, Deer
10. Fossils in the Stones Perry, Kids
11. The Great Lakes Ballet Company
12. Fraudway Company
13. Kick Rocks The Vandams

ACT II

14. Hands Come in Handy Lulu, Petoskey
15. Petoskey Company
16. North South East West (As Long As You Try Your Best) Jasper, Lulu
17. Rock Bottom Petoskey, Lulu
18. Family's in the Fossils Petey, Petoskey
19. Leave No Stones Unturned Wayland, The Vandams, Residents
20. Spirits Under the Bridge Lizzie, Petey
21. Michigan Company

👉 “Fossil in the Stones” is a David Quang Pham signature science song teaching paleontology.

ACT I

SCENE 1

EXT. ELK LAKE HOUSE IN ELK RAPIDS, AUGUST 2008 - DAY

1. "OVERTURE/THE MITTEN SONG"

In the wooded backyard of a lake house are tents where the Vandam family is camping. Nearby is Elk Lake's rocky shores.

PETEY (30s, man who's seen better days) crawls out his tent. He puts on oven mittens. With a melodic yawn, he bangs pots and pans.

PETEY

WAKEY WAKEY, SUN.
LET'S WEAR OUR MITTENS
AND COOK 'EM EGGS WITH LOTSA BACON
FOR OUR GODSEND,
MICHIGAN!

LIZZIE (30s, pregnant woman) reluctantly crawls out of Petey's tent. She's one decibel away from smacking her husband, Petey.

PETEY (CONT'D)

SLEPT WELL, HUN...?

End of "OVERTURE/THE MITTEN SONG"

2. "LIFE IS COMPLETE"

LIZZIE

(Narrating)

THAT'S THE LOVE OF MY LIFE.
BUT EVERY MORNING, HE'S PUBLIC ENEMY NUMBER ONE.

Petey joins Liz's side.

LIZZIE (CONT'D)

WHAT I MEANT TO SAY IS *PETEY IS FAMILY TO EVERYONE.*

PETEY

GET READY FOR IT'S...

SHELBY (V.O.)

LABOR DAY!

PETEY

WHAT...? NO.

PERRY (V.O.)
APRIL FOOLS!

PETEEY
IT'S AUGUST.

CHERRY (V.O.)
HAPPY HALLOWEEN!

PETEEY
WE'LL WEAR COSTUMES, BUT IT AIN'T HALLO-

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY (V.O.)
Merry Christmas/Happy Hannukkah/Joyous Kwanzaa!

PETEEY
JESUS H. CHRIST.
LET'S INCLUDE BOXING DAY WHILE YOU'RE AT IT!

MILLY (V.O.)
Petey, don't be celebrating false holidays...

WILLY (V.O.)
We ain't 'em darn Canadians, eh.

PETEEY
Mom, dad, please remind Cherry, Perry, Shelby
what this week is.

CHERRY (V.O.)	PERRY (V.O.)
We're messing with ya,	Seeing you nerd out is sorta
pipsqueak.	hilarious.

SHELBY (V.O.)
Your singing sucks more as the years go by.

LIZZIE
The days of bullying your brother is over. It's
my time to shine!

Liz holds a hand to Petey's face.

LIZZIE (CONT'D)
Eh eh eh, talk to the hand.

Petey puts his hand above Liz's
like the Michigan peninsulas.

PETEEY	LIZZIE (CONT'D)
MICHIGAN, IT'S HARBOR DAYS!	ELK RAPIDS, IT'S HARBOR DAYS!

GRANNY MILLY and GRAMPY WILLY are
lost, wandering in the audience.

MILLY	WILLY
GRAMPY WILLY.	GRANNY MILLY.

MILLY (CONT'D)
WE'VE GOT COMPANY.

WILLY (CONT'D)
LOOKS LIKE COMPANY.

Petey and Liz wave at Willy-Milly.

WILLY & MILLY
ISN'T LIFE SOMETHIN'?

Milly hands out cookies.

MILLY
YOU HAVE COME A LONG WAY, FRIENDS.

WILLY
TO THE GREATEST BAY IN ALL THE GREAT LAKES!

MILLY
BAKED YOUR KIDS FRESH COOKIES,
MAKE YOURSELF COMFY.

Willy takes off his shoes,
revealing his clam-covered feet.

WILLY
Emphasis on feet!

The pit musicians puke.

MILLY
Ugh! You're scaring the guests with your clam
feet!

WILLY
I've been working out. My feet have mussels. M-
U-S-S-E-L-S? Get it?

MILLY
...your dad jokes are getting old, Willy...

WILLY
Not as old as you, mama Milly...

MILLY
Shush! The guests are gonna think we're Midwest
silly instead of normal silly.

PETey
Ma! Pa! Who are you talking to???

LIZZIE
You should put ya parents in a retirement home.

WILLY & MILLY
Our hearing aids heard that! Maestro?!

Willy-Milly nod to the conductor.

WILLY & MILLY (CONT'D)
LIFE IS COMPLETE WITH YOUR CRAZY FAMILY!

The three Vandam sisters - CHERRY, PERRY, and SHELBY (pregnant) - run out of their tents and chase their brother, Petey. They catch him.

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
Hey Lizzie!

The sisters lick their fingers. Cherry and Perry stick their wet fingers in Petey's ears. Shelby does not know where to put hers.

WET WILLY! CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY (CONT'D)

PETTY
Ah!!! We're full grown adults!

LIZZIE
Nah dude, sisters always sisters.

Petey frees himself.

PETEY
GO MAKE YOUR DUMB COSTUMES, CHERRY.
PLAY WITH YOUR LAB EQUIPMENT, POINDEXTER PERRY.
WHERE IS YOUR WEIRD HUSBAND, BABY SISTER, SHELBY?

WILLY
Did someone say, wet... Uh...?

MILLY
Willly! Millyy?!

WILLY (CONT'D)

LIZZIE
No more singing Mitten Song and it'll all be
over.

Nevah!

VANDAMS
LIFE AIN'T COMPLETE WITHOUT...

Willy brings out the Ford Model T.

THE MODEL T!

MILLY CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
I'M GONNA TEABAG YOU, SO HELP DADDY LIKES HIS WHEELIES.
ME, WILLY.

WILLY
LIFE AIN'T COMPLETE WITHOUT MILLY!

CHERRY
CHERRY!

PERRY
PERRY!

SHELBY
SHELBY!

PETEEY
PETEEY AND HIS BESTIE...

JASPER (30s, Vietnamese man)
struts out of Petey's tent.

PETEEY (CONT'D) LIZZIE
Jasper! Got banh mi? Liz- Excuse me?

PETEEY (CONT'D)
You know Jasper Tran, we go way back!

JASPER
To the stone ages.

PETEEY
More like stoner ages, amirite?

LIZZIE
You two always being high, reminding everyone
you're childhood besties yadi yada...

JASPER
And that my fam owns the Viet restaurant, BANH
MIiiiiichigan!

PETEEY
Let's hit it up for ol' time sake!

MILLY
Lizzie, you needa give my son a hit!

PETEEY
LIFE AIN'T COMPLETE WITHOUT MY WIFEY!

LIZZIE
LIZZIE!

SHELBY
AND OUR BABIES...

MILLY WILLY
OUR GRANDKIDS... AH! GRANDKIDS!

LIZZIE

Watcha naming your daughter?

SHELBY

Lulu!

LIZZIE

Lulu. So full of life! Any particular meaning?

SHELBY

It means "pearl."

PETEEY

Arabic...? Ew.

SHELBY

And your ibnuki (إبنك)?

LIZZIE

No clue.

JASPER

I bet Petey's got an ace up his sleeves.

PETEEY

More like *stone*.

Petey and Jasper hop into Elk
Lake, splashing each other.

AMANDA WAYLAND (20s, all business)
enters from afar.

WAYLAND

Such a shame a happy family completes this lake
house when it's missing something. I mean, look
at this water. Disgusting. Just freely flowing
when it should be cooling my supercomputers.
The air... too pure to breathe. It needs the
spicy flavor of nuclear power. All families are
incomplete without pure dread. The Great Lakes
do bring out the worst. The Vandams will burst.

Wayland leaves into the shadows.

PETEEY

We won't name our son. Elk Lake will...

JASPER

Jasper! Jasper! Jasper!

LIZZIE

This gotta be a joke...

Petey dives in and finds a heart-
shaped, Elk-marked Petoskey stone.

Time stops. Everyone is in shock
at this rare rock.

LIZZIE (CONT'D)
WE AIN'T NAMING OUR SON THAT.

Liz walks off. Petey runs after.

JASPER
How about naming your second kid, Jasper?!

PETHEY
WE DON'T HAVE TO NAME HIM THAT.

LIZZIE
IT DOES SOUND LIKE PETHEY.

PETHEY
MY NAME JUST NEEDS AN O AND A KEY-

Liz kisses Petey.

LIZZIE
ISN'T LIFE BEAUTIFUL?

PETHEY (CONT'D)
ISN'T LIFE WORTH LIVING?

VANDAMS
LIFE IS COMPLETE WITH OUR

JASPER
LIFE IS COMPLETE WITH THIS

LIZZIE
CRAZY

PETHEY
SASSY

CHERRY
WORKY

PERRY
NERDY

SHELBY
DERPY

WILLY
WILLY

MILLY
LOVELY

JASPER
WELCOMING...

VANDAMS
FAMILY!

End of "LIFE IS COMPLETE"

Liz's flip phone rings. She answers and listens.

LIZZIE

Thanks for giving us a sinking feeling!

Liz slams her flip phone.

PETEY

Is it the baby?

LIZZIE

The recession got us too. The shipyard has fired us and replaced us. 2008 can't get any better. Those darn migrants.

Petey sees Shelby looking fondly at photos of her Arab husband on her phone.

PETEY

The outsiders hurt us, blue-collared workers.

LIZZIE

We're gonna lose our house to a foreclosure. So, don't be burning bridges...

Petey sobs, as everyone leaves. He looks as Elk Lake turns into the Mackinac Strait under its bridge.

SCENE 2

EXT. MACKINAC BRIDGE - EVENING

3. "BODY OF WATER"

Out in the storm, Petey walks onto the foggy creaky bridge.

PETEY

EVERY LIVING THING IS MADE OF WATER.
EVERY MACHINERY NEEDS THE FLOW OF WATER.
ALL THE WEATHER TAKE THE HEATED WATER.
ALL THE SEASONS BRING THE COOLING WATER.

Petey notices the raindrops.

PETEY (CONT'D)

I BRING NOTHING TO THE WORLD UNLIKE WATER.
I'VE BROUGHT NOTHING TO THE WORLD BUT TEARS!

The Mackinac ghosts appear, resembling those who passed there. They try to hand a mug to Petey.

MACKINAC GHOSTS

DRINK IT. DRINK THE WATER.
THINK STRAIGHT. THINK STRAIGHTFORWARD.

PETHEY

I BRING NOTHING TO THE WORLD.

MACKINAC GHOSTS

CHERISH. CHERISH THIS ONE LIFE.

PETHEY

JUST TEARS!
HELP!

The ghosts steal Petey's stone.

MACKINAC GHOSTS

HELP? HELL, HELP YOURSELF!

A motherly ghost returns with a
Petoskey necklace. Petey wears it.

PETHEY

I CHOOSE LIFE!

MACKINAC GHOSTS (CONT'D)

TAKE IT IN.

PETHEY (CONT'D)

DRINK THE GREAT LAKES WATER.
THINK PAIN. PAIN YOU'LL CAUSE.
HAPPY WIFE. BABY IN SIGHT. DYING AIN'T RIGHT.

MACKINAC GHOSTS

DRINK IT. DRINK THE WATER.
THINK STRAIGHT. THINK STRAIGHTFORWARD.
CHERISH. CHERISH LIGHT.

PETHEY

HELP MYSELF TO THIS GREAT WATER!

Petey drinks his mug, starts the
car, and drives away.

Morning approaches with the
emergency vehicles. The orchestra
wails the sirens.

Liz rushes in with the DETECTIVE.
She stops in her tracks, kneeling.

LIZZIE

Life is a complete... disaster...

DETECTIVE

We are sorry to report the vehicle submerged
underneath Mackinac Bridge has been identified
as yours... and the body-

LIZZIE
(Narrating)

-NOW OF WATER.
IN THIS BODY OF WATER...
UNDER THE BRIDGE...
WITH MY LAST TEAR,
I'M OUTTA WATER IN MY BODY...

The Detective gives the Petoskey necklace to Liz. They leave as Liz breaks down.

End of "BODY OF WATER"

LIZZIE (CONT'D)

A bridge is supposed to unite two lands, not divide two souls. The water may be under it, I have vowed to never set foot on a bridge that double-crossed my heart. The strait stole my balance, silenced my music, drowned my love, eroded me into a cold, hard-

Shelby, now with a black eye and some bruises, hugs Liz. She encourages Liz to open her hand to reveal the Petoskey necklace.

LIZZIE (CONT'D)

Every rock has a softness they need to find in themselves. Perhaps, it'll take time in unexpected places... and persons... And yes, in the end, Petey got me to name our baby...

Liz places the necklace in the center. She leaves.

SCENE 3

EXT. ELK LAKE HOUSE IN ELK RAPIDS, AUGUST 2019 - DAY

4. "YOOPERS AND TROLLS"

PETOSKEY (11, farm boy) crawls out of his tent. He sees the Petoskey necklace and wears it. He puts on mittens and bangs pots and pans.

LULU (11, city girl in a Hijab) crawls out of her tent and trolls Petoskey.

LULU

...Petoskey!

PETOSKEY

Lulu!

LULU
Shut... up, Yooper!

PETOSKEY (CONT'D)
Pipe... down, Troll.

Cherry, Perry, and Shelby enter
with lawn chairs. They sit.

CHERRY
The kids are at it again?

SHELBY
With my daughter, you betcha.

PERRY
Let's be responsible... and place some bets.

SHELBY
Let's go Lulu! Your inheritance in on the line!

Petoskey takes off his mittens as
Lulu gives troll-like expressions.

PETOSKEY
HOLY WAH! ANOTHER DAY TO GO FISHING!

LULU
YEAH NO... TODAY, WE GO BIRD WATCHING.

PETOSKEY
AREN'T YOU FROM EH... DEARBORN?

LULU
I AIN'T INTO DEER, YOU WILD YOOPERS...

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
UNDER THE BRIDGE.
OVER THE MITTEN.
YOOPERS AND TROLLS.

PETOSKEY
EH, CRAZY TROLLS...
LET'S GO STARGAZING!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
WHAT ABOUT 'EM MOSQUITOES?

LULU
LET'S JUST WATCH WCMU-TV!

PETOSKEY
WLUC IS UP THERE!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
WOOD-TV 8 IS BETTER! (MOSQUITOES!)

LULU
I WILL BITE. I AM DOWN TO GO KAYAKING!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
UNDER THE BRIDGE.
OVER THE MITTEN!
PINE RIVER, THE FASTEST IN MICHIGAN!

Petoskey draws his water gun, but
Lulu shoots hers first.

PETOSKEY
ATTACK!

LULU
TOO SLOW!

PETOSKEY
I'VE GOT BACKUP!

JACOB JACOBOWITZ (young adult,
returned home from acting in NYC)
and the OTHER COUSINS (kids)
ambush Lulu with their water guns
before retreating.

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
YOU WILL NEVER STAY DRY!
UNDER THE BRIDGE.
OVER THE MITTEN!

PETOSKEY
THANK YOU, COUSINS!

LULU
IT IS A SIN TO TARGET YOUR FAVORITE COUSIN.

Jacob hands a towel to Lulu. They
hug before he exits. She dries up.

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
(Repeating)
YOOPERS AND TROLLS.

LULU
HOLY CRAP, I HATE *HATE* CAMPING WITH YOU.

PETOSKEY
NO ONE LIKES YOUR HIP HOP TRASH.

LULU
TAKE IT BACK, COUNTRY BOY.

PETOSKEY
YOU FIRST, CITY GAL.

LULU & PETOSKEY
ANOTHER HARBOR DAYS...

LULU
...WITH THIS WILD YOOPER...

Lulu wrestles Petoskey.

PETOSKEY
STAY UNDER THE BRIDGE, TROLL!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
YOOPERS AND TROLLS FORM A BRIDGE!

WILLY & MILLY
STOP FIGHTING!

End of "YOOPERS AND TROLLS"

[Liz narrates, sharing the course of actions that take place before July 2022, mainly after August 2019 Harbor Days.

Liz refuses to cross the Mackinac Bridge to attend Harbor Days but hopes Petoskey would get to enjoy it. His aunties - Cherry, Perry, and Shelby - take turns driving Petoskey from Skandia in the Upper Peninsula to Elk Rapids in the Lower.

Cherry's son Jacob gets along with Petoskey, but grows up to become an actor in New York City. He recently did The Addams Family national tour.

Shelby's same-age daughter Lulu however do not get along with Petoskey. It mirrors Shelby's tumultuous relationship with her late older brother, Petey.

After Harbor Days, Grammy Milly drives Petoskey home. Whenever they cross the Mackinac Bridge, he hears his father singing. He has only seen and heard his father through Perry's camcorder recordings.

In Petey's absence, his childhood friend Jasper Tran becomes Petoskey's godfather during Harbor Days and babysitting. He also becomes a godbrother to the aunties. His Vietnamese restaurant BANH MICHIGAN is the family goto spot for food.

At the end of August 2019, Petoskey returns heartbroken. Liz does not know but Lulu threw Petey's heirloom into Elk Lake. It is Petoskey's spiritual connection to his late father.

In 2020, Grammy Milly passes away. Due to COVID, Grampy Willy refuses to host family reunions in 2020 and 2021.]

INT. HOME IN SKANDIA, JULY 2022 - DAY

Petoskey sits sadly, looking at
photos of him and Milly.

Liz levels with Petoskey.

LIZZIE

Son, I know how much Grammy Milly meant to you.
So, would it mean the world if I went to this
year's Harbor Days? August two ol' two two.

PETOSKEY

You'd cross the bridge?

LIZZIE

Nah. We'll take the long way through Wisconsin.

PETOSKEY

That's not fair! Everyone's cheesy there...

LIZZIE

Let's get a MOOooooove on. For Milly's sake.

Liz and Petoskey exit.

SCENE 4

INT. ELK LAKE HOUSE - LIVING ROOM - DAY

5. "IT WOULD BE A SHAME"

Willy stares longingly at a photo
of his late wife Milly.

Amanda Wayland knocks on the door.
Willy goes and open it.

WAYLAND

I NEED YOUR LAKE HOUSE!

Willy slams the door on Wayland.

WILLY

THOSE DAMN VULTURES.

MILLY (V.O.)

WHO ARE YOU CALLING A VULTURE?

Willy opens the door again.
Wayland nabs Milly's photo.

WAYLAND

AND YOU NEED YOUR WIFE BACK.
MY NAME'S AMANDA WAYLAND OF TURKEY VENTURES...
AND I CAN BRING YOUR WIFE TO LIFE!

Wayland displays her tablet.

WILLY

SHE DID NOT BELIEVE IN ALCHEMY.

Wayland places Milly's photo on her tablet.

WAYLAND
THIS IS NOT ALCHEMY.
IT IS TECHNOLOGY!

Milly shows up behind Wayland.

MILLY
SO PROUD OF YOU.

WAYLAND
YOU HEARD THAT?

Wayland raises the tablet volume.

MILLY
I LOVE YOU!!

WAYLAND
I'D LOVE YOU TO LET ME BUILD A DATA CENTER BY YOUR LAKE.
SO, SHE CAN GET THE WATER SHE NEEDS.

MILLY
DO NOT BRING SHAME.

Willy looks at the disapproving violinists in the orchestra.

WAYLAND
DON'T BE ASHAMED TO SAY "NO."

WILLY
NO.

Milly disappears.

Wayland expects it. She "respects" his decision. Before closing the door, she nabs Petey's photo. Outside, she sets it on her tablet.

Petey enters the home.

PETEY
WASN'T MY LIFE WORTH MORE THAN MY HOUSE?

MILLY
IT'D BE A SHAME...

PETEY
WASN'T MY BREATH WORTH MORE THAN SOME LAKE?

MILLY
IT'D BE A SHAME...

PETEY
WASN'T HEART WORTH MORE THAN THESE ROCKS?

WILLY
THERE IS NO SHAME IN FORGETTING THEM.

Milly joins Petey's side.

PETEY, MILLY, WAYLAND
SHAME...
SHAME...
ASHAMED...
ONLY SHAME...
NOTHING STAYS THE SAME...

WILLY
IT WOULD BE A SHAME IF I CHOSE THE HOUSE BEFORE MY FAMILY!
IT WOULD BE A SHAME IF I MAKE...

WAYLAND
BRING BACK YOUR WIFE!

PETEY & MILLY
DON'T BE ASHAMED!

WILLY
IT'D BE A SHAME IF I MAKE THE...

PETEY & MILLY
THERE IS NO SHAME.

WAYLAND
BRING BACK YOUR SON!

WILLY
IT'D BE A SHAME IF I MAKE THE SAME...

PETEY, MILLY, WAYLAND
NOTHING STAYS THE SAME...

WILLY	WAYLAND
IT'D BE SHAME IF I MAKE THE	IT'D BE A SHAME IF YOU MADE
SAME MISTAKE...	THE SAME...

PETEY, MILLY, WAYLAND
IT'D BE A SHAME!

Willy tries to hug Milly and
Petey. But they disappear.
Instead, he hugs a tablet with
their photos. The tablet displays
a contract. He holds the e-pen.

End of "[IT WOULD BE A SHAME](#)"

SCENE 5

EXT. ELK LAKE HOUSE IN ELK RAPIDS, AUGUST 2022 - DAY

6. "DAD TAX"

Jasper finishes setting up Lulu
and Petoskey's tents.

Shelby and Lizzie stare in awe as
Lulu and Petoskey feel awful.

SHELBY
Thanks for everything, Jasper.

LULU
I really did not need your help.

PETOSKEY
You needed all the help you can get, Lulu.

JASPER
And you needed manpower.

LULU
Ha! He called you a sissy, Petoskey!

LIZZIE
How could we ever repay you?

JASPER
Your sweetness is good 'nough for me.

Jasper nabs a handful of candy
from Lulu and Petoskey's box.

LULU & PETOSKEY
That's *my* candy.

Lulu and Petoskey stare down one
another as they fight for the box.

LULU & PETOSKEY (CONT'D)
Mine! My sweets! Sugar! Mine!

Jasper takes their box away.

JASPER
In the jurisdiction vested by the council of
fathers and godfathers, everything is mine.

LULU & PETOSKEY
What jurisdiction?

Jasper pulls out his "Dad Rules!"
book. He opens it for the kids to
skim then promptly shuts it.

JASPER
YOU KIDS GOT NO SAY...

LULU, PETOSKEY, KIDS
SO TAXATION WITHOUT REPRESENTATION?

JASPER
IT'S GOOD FOR THE COMMUNITY!

LULU, PETOSKEY, KIDS
THAT'S WHAT A COMMUNIST WOULD SAY!

JASPER
JUST PAYA YOUR FAIR SHARE!

LULU, PETOSKEY, KIDS
NEVER!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
DAD RULES!
TAX SEASON!
CAMP REASONS!
COME COLLECT:

The Vandam aunties tax and collect
from the kids on Jasper's behalf.

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY (CONT'D)	LULU, PETOSKEY, KIDS
YOUR COOKIES!	MY COOKIES!
YOUR CANDIES!	MY CANDY!
YOUR FRENCH FRIES!	MY FRENCH FRIES!
YOUR MILK SHAKES!	MY MILK SHAKE!
YOUR CHICKEN!	MY CHICKEN!
YOUR NUGGETS!	MY NUGGETS!
YOUR KID'S MEALS!	MY KID'S MEAL!
YOUR ROBLOX!	MY ROBLOX!
YOUR MINECRAFT!	MY MINECRAFT!
YOUR FREEDOM!	OUR CIVIL LIBERTIES!

JASPER
YOU'VE GOT TRANSPORTATION...
DRINKING WATER...

Jasper drinks the milk shakes.

JASPER (CONT'D)
THERE'RE NOW CAMP GOODS AND SERVICES...
ALL THANKS TO THE DAD TAX!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
PAY YOUR DAD TAX!

[Liz sings about the mom tax. It is more egregious than the dad tax. The kids start a Boston Tea Party-esque revolution due to being dad and mom taxed without kid representation.]

End of "DAD TAX"

Jasper, the Vandam sisters, and
the kids gather by the bonfire.

JASPER

Looks during the revolution, you all started
the fire! A perfect bonfire to honor Grammy
Milly. I'll go get Grampy Willy.

Jasper goes inside the lake house.

LULU

One can only wish for a godfather like Jasper.

PETOSKEY

You just saw him and our moms tax us.

LIZZIE & SHELBY

We gave you welfare in the world, we can tax
you out of it.

Jasper enters with Willy. He pulls
up a chair.

JASPER

Why don't you have a seat here?

Willy sits. Everyone sit down.

CHERRY

We gather here today to honor the life of
Grammy Willy. It's been a couple years since
Milly left this world...

WILLY

Actually, Milly came back a couple days ago.

Everyone stares at Willy like an
old man who lost his marbles.

PERRY

Like in your dreams?

SHELBY

Putting him in a nursing home is gonna be a
nightmare.

Willy pulls out a tablet.

WILLY

Home is here. So is my favorite nurse... on
this phone.

PERRY

That's too big for a phone.

CHERRY

It's how big they were back then.

SHELBY

Dad, you can't just call the after life.

WILLY

Milly, please call.

Milly appears on the tablet.

MILLY

Way ahead of you.

Everyone is disturbed.

LULU, PETOSKEY, KIDS

She looks so real!

WILLY

She is.

PERRY

No, she's not.

CHERRY

She... Don't break dad's heart again.

WILLY

You all have seen enough of your mama. I can ask Petey to call.

Liz covers Petey's eyes and ears.

LIZZIE

No no no.

JASPER

What did this cost?

WILLY

Very little.

CHERRY

How much?

WILLY

My son was worth more than...

LIZZIE

...the house...?!

Wayland slyly steps in.

WAYLAND

Yes, access to Afterlife dot AI was on the house. I see it's a perfect time to come in when everyone seems fired up. Cherry.

CHERRY

Amanda...

WAYLAND

How's making 'em kiddie costumes for your dumb Harbor Days parade?

CHERRY

How's making anything? That's right. You can't.

LULU

Who's she?

PERRY

Amanda Wayland was Cherry's classmate in art school

CHERRY

Until she was caught cheating with Photoshop.

WAYLAND

And now everyone's using Photoshop.

SHELBY

Don't you use that, Cherry?

CHERRY

Shut up. I use Corel.

SHELBY

You're such a geezer. Who uses Corel?

PERRY

You geezer. Who uses Corel? Snapchats then or now even if your life depended on it.

WAYLAND

Now, everyone around the world depends on me to get through the day, answer questions smart and dumb, answer questions dumb and brilliant, read novels, write essays, entire musicals-

LULU & JACOB

Shut the f-

CHERRY & SHELBY

Language.

WAYLAND

I didn't get to the best part of. It does the impossible. It brings the

PETOSKEY

Deadarse...

Everyone stares down Liz.

LIZZIE

We Yoopers do not police language.

CHERRY

Get out.

WAYLAND

You're impressed.

PERRY

Depressed. Seriously, get out.

SHELBY

Vamos!

JASPER

Willy, implore this amorally ambiguous woman to leave the premises.

WAYLAND

The premise is... I own your lake house.
There's a Willy, there's a way. Willy, thanks
for not making the same mistake your son made.

7. "AFFORDABLE"

WAYLAND

CAN YOU AFFORD IT?

LIZZIE

You're wrong. He'd say the house is like family
and worth everything. How about my house near
Marquette?

PETOSKEY

Mom?

LIZZIE

Why would you want a rundown house when you can
have one with the latest amenities, including a
bidet?

[The family sings about affordability. They make reference to their century-old Ford Model T. No one could afford the house back. Wayland takes a tour of the home where it has walls of photos. She eyes a photo of a young Petoskey wearing his father's heirloom: a heart-shaped Petoskey stone with a marking of an Elk. Lulu and her mom Shelby are not present to know the importance of this stone to Petoskey and Liz. The lost heirloom is their only chance of saving the lake house. Wayland would trade the deed for it.]

WAYLAND

No one outgrows collecting cool rocks,
especially a Petoskey. This one seems like it's
worth a whole Great Lake.

LIZZIE

It's my husband's heirloom.

WAYLAND

The owner is dead. Now, it's worth two Great
Lakes. Unlike him, is it here?

CHERRY & PERRY

Somewhere...

WAYLAND

Perfect. Everything on the premise is also
mine.

PETOSKEY

It's not yours.

WAYLAND

Your son's trade should be in law.

LIZZIE

Really?

WAYLAND

No.

PETOSKEY

Grammy Milly gave it to me. It's her last gift.

WAYLAND

How about a trade?

PETOSKEY

The house...

WAYLAND

...for your cool rock. Well, produce it.

PETOSKEY

I wanna put on a show. I need a whole day.

WAYLAND

Tomorrow after the parade?

LIZZIE

Tomorrow after the parade.

LIZZIE (CONT'D)

Is the Petoskey back in Skandia?

PETOSKEY

Closer. At the bottom of Elk Lake.

LIZZIE

What'? How did that happen?

Petoskey imitates Lulu.

LIZZIE (CONT'D)

Lulu?

[Conveniently, Jasper and Aunt Perry run a scuba diving company. But they could not find the heirloom ("Heirlooms"). The next few nights, Lulu and Petoskey witness deer pass by the bonfire. He wishes to see his dad while she hopes to win this year's rock collection ("Dearborn"). One day, while Perry teaches fossils to the kids ("Fossils in the Stones"), Lulu separates from the group and discovers a deer drop off the hearty Petoskey necklace and other rare stones on the shore ("The Great Lakes Ballet").]

For Harbor Days' parade, Broadway actor cousin Jacob Jacobowitz is the MC. So, the theme is theatre. Petoskey dresses as *Oklahoma's* Jud Fry while Lulu plays *Evan Hansen*. Before marching, she shows her rare stone findings to the family. To spite Petoskey, she breaks his father's necklace, unaware it was their only chance to save the lake house from Wayland. The parade goes wrong as Petoskey beats up Lulu, disqualifying them for the first time ("Fraudway"). After a lecture, he runs away ("Kick Rocks").]

END OF ACT I

ACT II**SCENE 1**

[In the following act, the family revisits a memory of Lulu and Petoskey meeting ("Hands Come in Handy"). Presently, they search for him while Lulu tries to find him at BANH MI ("Petoskey"). Jasper shares his refugee family stayed united despite continents dividing them as well as a time when a Lebanese family bought out his family's failing restaurant but did not resort to blame as Petey had. The Vandams are only divided by peninsulas. Lulu realizes Petoskey is most likely at the Mackinac Bridge ("North South East West").

They drive up to find him. She offers the broken stone as a truce, but he tosses it into the water ("Rock Bottom"). This causes the bridge to fog up where his father's ghost emerges as a giant elk. Petey shares that stones are special only when rocks are packed together. Like family, rocks come and go to leave a mark ("Family's in the Fossils").

They return to the fair where Wayland is exhibiting data center models with other developers. Petoskey offers the Ford which she scoffs but is interested in. Jasper then offers his restaurant. The Vandams return with decades of themed costume while Wayland shows how much "better" AI is. But the town rallies for this genuinely creative and weird family, against AI's goal of turning lakes into data centers. Wayland and the developers refuse and steal the Ford, causing the town to chase after them. She drives it off a bridge, then gets thrown into an asylum by Traverse City. Their contracts are declared void as their party is declared insane ("Leave No Stones Unturned").]

Liz gets in the Ford Model T.
Petoskey joins her on the
passenger side.

LIZZIE

Son... We're taking the shortcut.

SCENE +

EXT. MACKINAC BRIDGE - DAY

20. "SPIRITS UNDER THE BRIDGE"

On the foggy bridge is the broken
Petoskey necklace.

Liz drives towards the outskirts
of the bridge. She motions for
Petoskey to stay put. She walks
alone on the bridge.

Liz wears one mitten and
accidentally lets another fly off.

LIZZIE
(Teary)

WAKEY WAKEY, HUN.
LET'S WEAR MY MITTEN-

PETHEY (V.O.)

OUR MITTENS...

Liz senses a presence. She picks
up the broken Petoskey necklace.

LIZZIE & PETHEY
AND FILL OUR CHEST WITH LOTSA LOVIN'
FOR OUR GODSEND...

The Michiganders hold hands.

LIZZIE & PETHEY (CONT'D)

MICHIGAN!

Liz pulls Petey out of the fog.
After fourteen years, the lovers
embrace. They kiss.

End of "SPIRITS UNDER THE BRIDGE"

END OF ACT II

ACT III

SCENE 1

EXT. ELK RAPIDS, 2037 - DAY

21. "MICHIGAN"

[Liz narrates, sharing the course of actions that take place between 2022 and 2037.]

Years later, Willy passes away. Lulu and Petoskey buy and fix up the lake house.

For the 2037 Harbor Days which celebrates two hundred years of statehood (January 26, 1837), the theme is Pure Michigan where the Vandam family resembles the state's best from Eminem, Aretha Franklin, Charles Lindbergh, Madonna, Malcolm X, Rosa Parks, Stevie Wonder.]

END OF MUSICAL